

EDUCATION

With literacy rates lingering at 61 per cent, India still has a long way to go, but it is only when education is taken up as a cause by ordinary citizens, that the difference starts to show. Like Abhyanand of Bihar, who is helping dreams come true for hundreds of underprivileged young students by coaching them for the prestigious IITs, or Pravin Mahajan, whose organisation is educating children of migrant workers across sugar factories in Maharashtra. One passion binds them all—to spread education to India's far-flung corners in the most basic way. As Amartya Sen asserts, "Widening the coverage and effectiveness of basic education can have a powerfully preventive role in reducing human insecurity of nearly every kind." The government may build the most grandiose schemes—whether it is the Sarva Shiksha Abhiyan, that was launched in 2001, or the National Literacy Mission, which began in 1988—but until every literate Indian adopts one who is not, education will remain a luxury.

■ By Amitabh Srivastava

With his sharply-creased police uniform, carefully-combed hair and flashy cell phone, he looks every bit an upwardly mobile IPS officer, and just as every bit out of place in a classroom full of clamouring children. But there is no doubt that Abhyanand is perfectly at ease here, smiling while teaching Class V

students the tenets of mental mathematics, which includes shortcuts to solve problems without the use of multiplication tables.

The Additional Director-General of Police, Bihar Military Police, pops a question and the children look momentarily flummoxed, but Abhyanand patiently nudges them into speaking up, simultaneously provoking them with multiple options. The indulgent teacher finally smiles when a 10-year-old tells him the right answer and explains why it is so. "To me, a teacher is someone who never gives the right answer, but keeps asking the right questions. My job is to encourage my students to come up with the right answers," says the IPS officer with deep conviction in his voice.

"Asking questions is important for a teacher because transferring concepts is not like copying files from one computer and pasting it on another," says Abhyanand. "We need to activate the students' brains and develop their lateral thinking abilities." This is a doctrine that has seen his Super 30 programme click year after year. The programme—a free IIT entrance coaching course for 30 select youngsters from underprivileged families in rural Bihar—saw 18 out of 30 in the first batch make it to the premier technology institutions in 2003. The success rate has been soaring with every passing year as 20 students qualified in 2004 and 22 got through the next year. In 2006, the number of students who cleared the entrance was 26, rising to 28 in 2007. This year, the results for the programme were even better, as everyone from the Super 30 group made the grade in what is widely believed to be one of the toughest and most competitive entrance examinations in the world.

For Abhyanand, who tutors the IIT aspirants in physics, the tryst with teaching began rather by chance in 1989 when his

son, Shwetank, then a Class I student, scored zero out of 10 in a class test on single-digit multiplication. "My wife held me responsible for this, and so I was forced to give teaching a try. I asked my son a question: what is the biggest number in the world? Shwetank was silent for a moment and then said, 'There can't be such a number, as I can always add one to it.' The boy had accidentally come across the concept of infinity, and I discovered the teacher within me," he reminisces.

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